Softw**here** Associates

Power-Choice

The Ultimate Menu System

User's Guide

Power-Choice User's Guide

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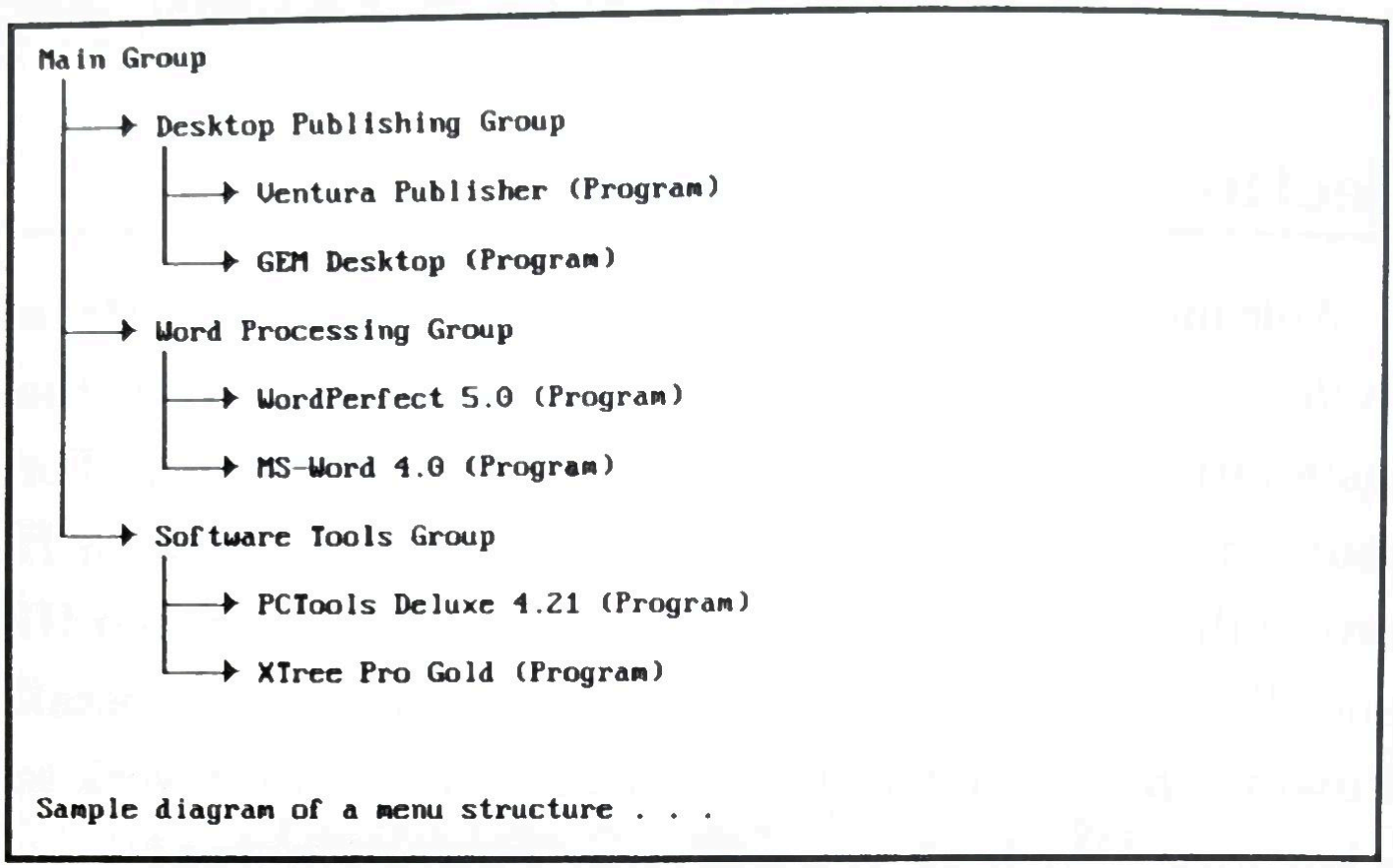
Section I - Introduction

Welcome to **Power-Choice**, the *Ultimate Menu System*! This brief manual will help you with the installation process and the use of **Power-Choice**. For your convenience, it is divided into 5 sections. Section II covers the basic components of a menu system, Section III and IV however will explain how to use and install **Power-Choice** in detail so you can cut down your work to a keypress ! We hope you will enjoy **Power-Choice** !

Section II - What is a Menu System ?

A Menu System enables you to choose the program you wish to activate without having to remember long and complicated DOS commands. Once you have the menu set up, one keypress will start up the desired program. After the installation and setup of your menu, you will be presented with the selection screen every time you start your computer.

Several programs of the same type should be arranged in separate groups, whereas groups are arranged in a "tree structure" descending from the Main Group. (see diagram on the next page)



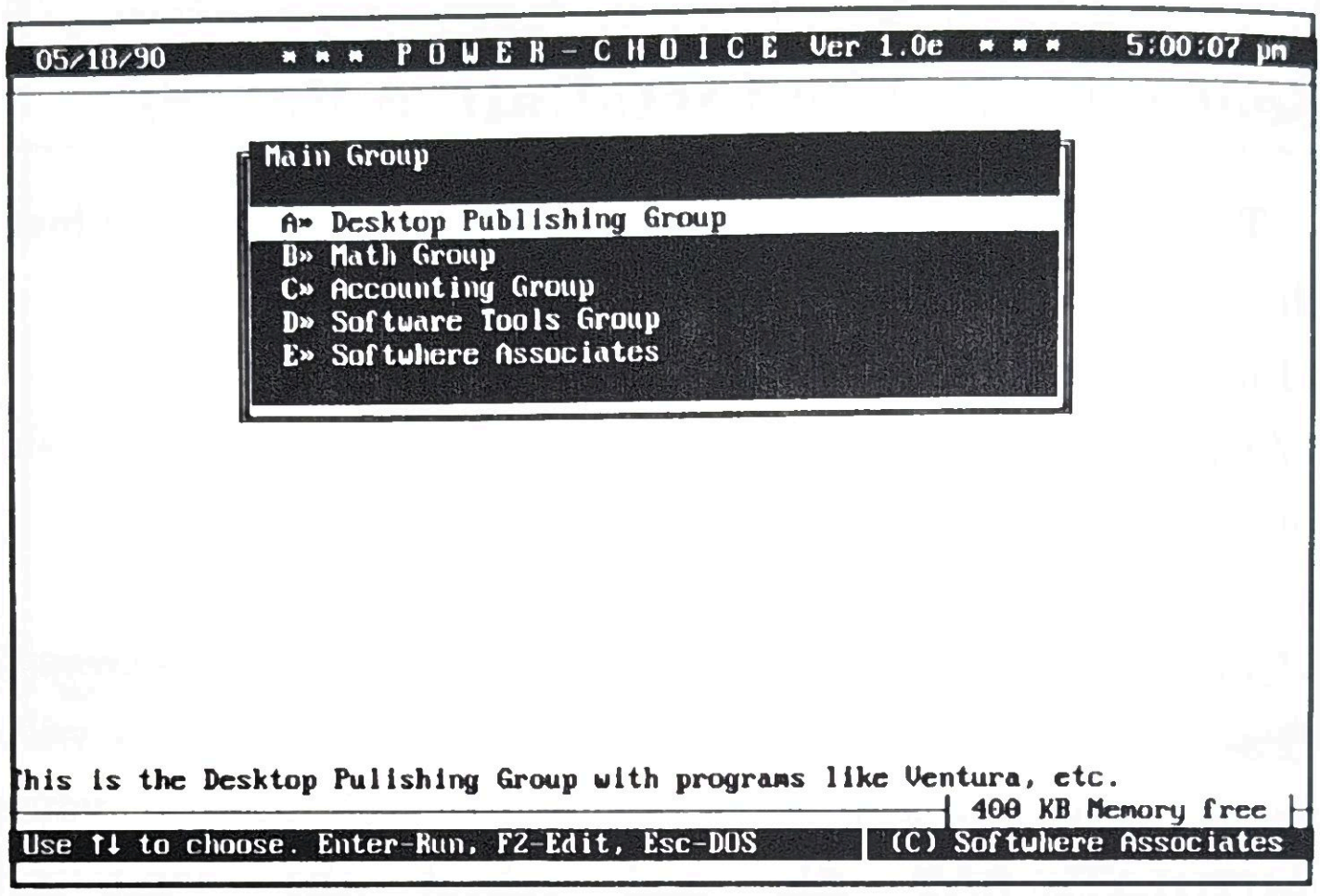
You have to start building your structure from the Main Group down to the individual programs. To change groups, simply point at the new group and hit Enter. The term "Parent Group" refers to the group from which the current group originated. (The Main Group does not have a Parent Group !) For example, in the diagram above, the Main Group is the Parent Group of the Word Processing Group. To return to the Parent Group simply press Tab. Any group can branch to another group as well as contain items that actually refer to programs.

Section III - The Installation Process

To install **Power-Choice** on your harddisk, just follow these few, simple steps !

- Put the **Power-Choice** disk in any drive.
- At the DOS prompt change to the drive you put the disk in by typing A: or B: and hit Enter.
- Type PCHINST and press Enter.
- The installation program will then offer a choice between "Easy" and "Custom" installation. Easy installation will install **Power-Choice** in C:\PCHOICE, update your AUTOEXEC.BAT file and reboot the computer automatically by asking you a minimum number of questions, whereas Custom installation allows you to change the defaults and paths individually. Either one will suffice.

NOTE: The built-in screen saver that prevents monitors from burning in, only works with Hercules Monochrome cards, CGA graphics cards and some EGA cards. For that reason you will not even be asked whether you want to enable the screen saver if you have a VGA card. If the screen saver creates problems with the screen display, reinstall **Power-Choice** not using the screen saver at all!



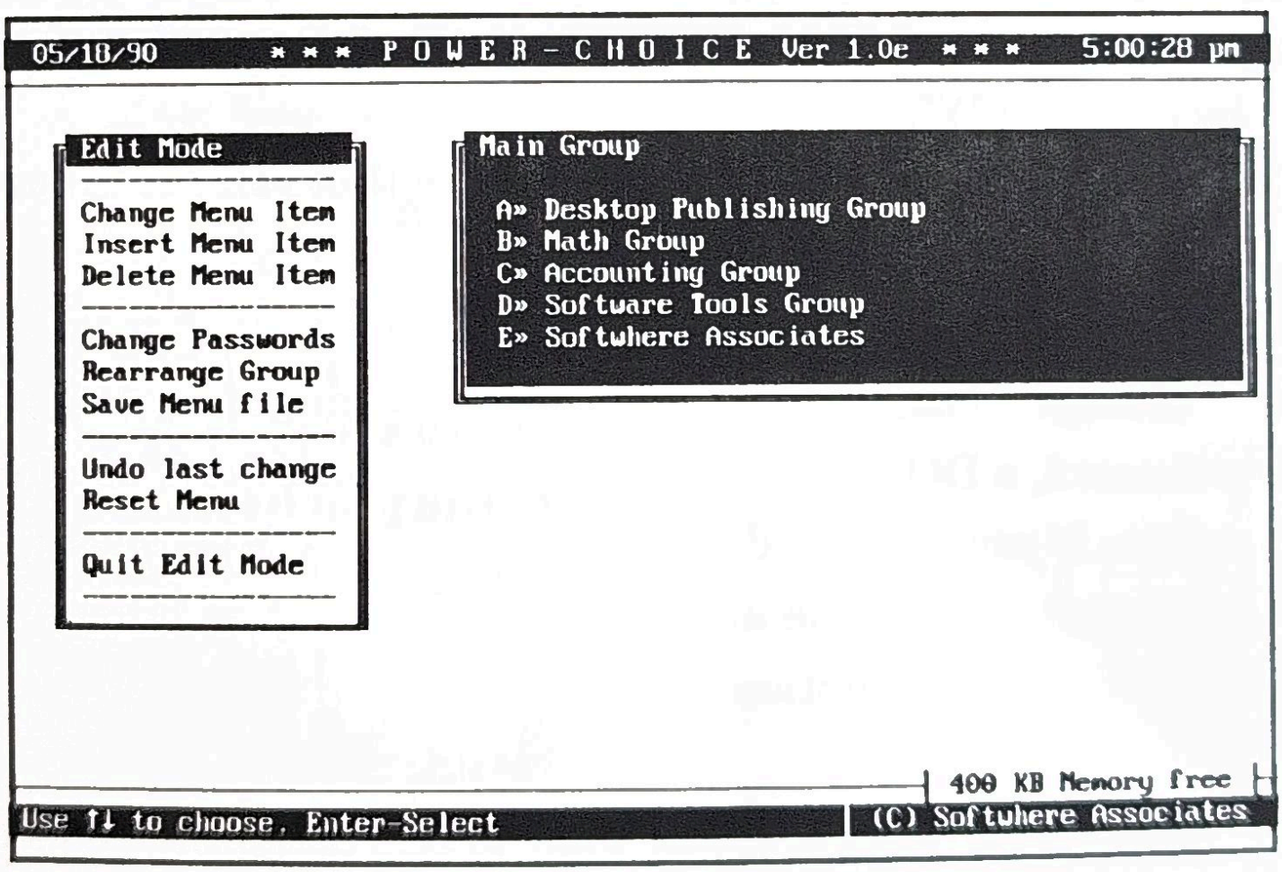
Section IV - Getting started

Please read all of this section carefully before continuing your installation !

After the installation process, a reboot is necessary. (If you choose "Easy Installation", this will be done automatically !) After a few seconds, **Power-Choice** will appear, showing you the (still) empty Main Group. **Power-Choice** displays the current group in the middle of the screen and a key/function description at the very bottom of the screen which displays all the options available.

Before customizing your menu structure it is wise to consider the Main Group components as well as all programs you want to incorporate. Make a short list of programs and how to load them. For example if you want to install a program called TEST, you need to know the path where it resides and the command to start it. Having finished your list, press **F2** to enter the Edit Mode. You will be presented with a list of operations available.

The Edit Mode



Change Menu Item - Is used to change a single menu item within the current group. You will be prompted to select the item you want to change. You will work within an entry screen that will be described later.

Insert Menu Item - Is used to introduce a new item to the current page. After selecting the new position, then choose between "Command Item" or "Group Item". If you select "Command Item" you create an item that calls a single program. "Group Item", will create a new, empty group. In order to insert items in this new group, however it is necessary to leave the Edit Mode by pressing Esc and change to the new group (Highlight it and press Enter). Then press **F2** to return to Edit Mode !

Delete Menu Item - Is used to delete an item out of the current group. Just highlight the desired item and confirm by pressing "Y".
NOTE: You cannot delete group items that refer to groups that are not empty.

Change Passwords - To define/change a Log-On password, a DOS password and an Edit password, use this option. If you want to define a Log-On or DOS password, it is advisable to define an Edit password also, as otherwise the access to this option is not restricted.

Rearrange Group - If you want to rearrange the order of the items within a group, choose this option. Then select the item to move and place it wherever you desire. The lettering will be automatically adjusted.

Save Menu File - Usually not used, as every change will try to save automatically. In case of I/O-error though, it is possible to abort and save later after correcting the mistake.

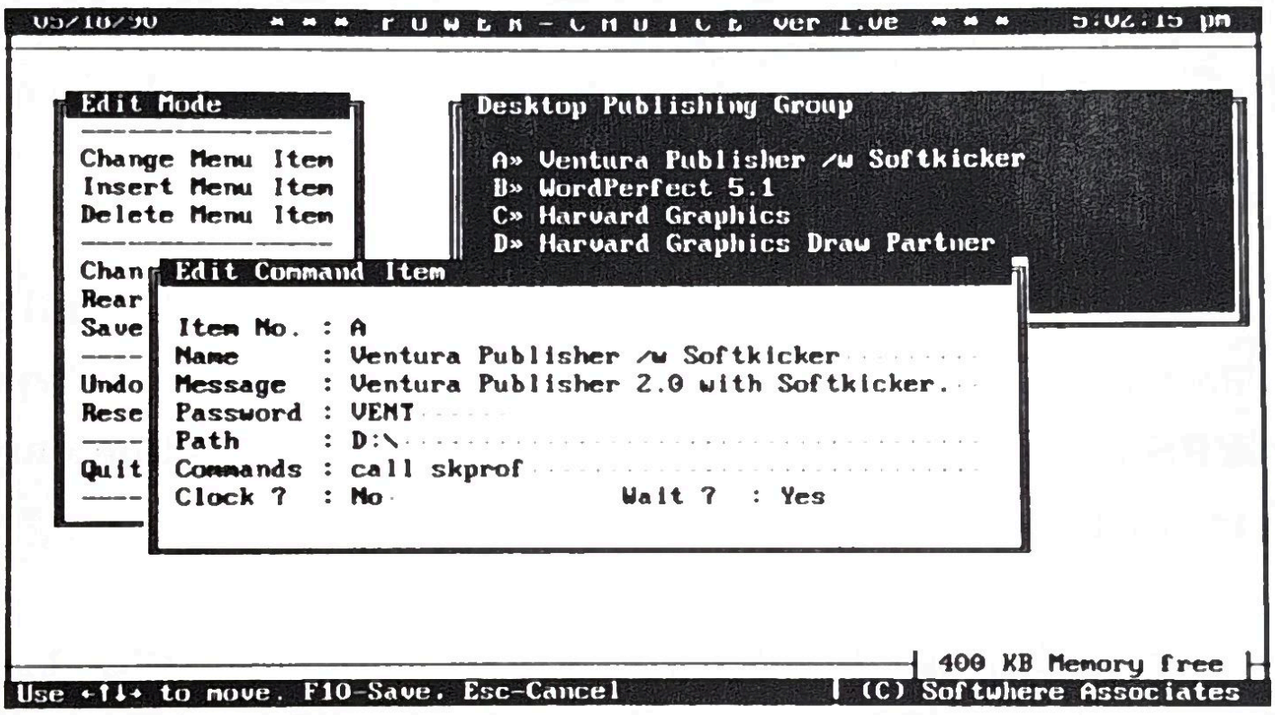
Undo Last Change - In case of an unwanted change, it is possible to undo only the very last change that you made. (This can be very useful !)

Reset Menu - **CAUTION** - This function will totally destroy your menu structure. Thus it is necessary to type **YES** before anything will be done. Use this function only to start from scratch !!

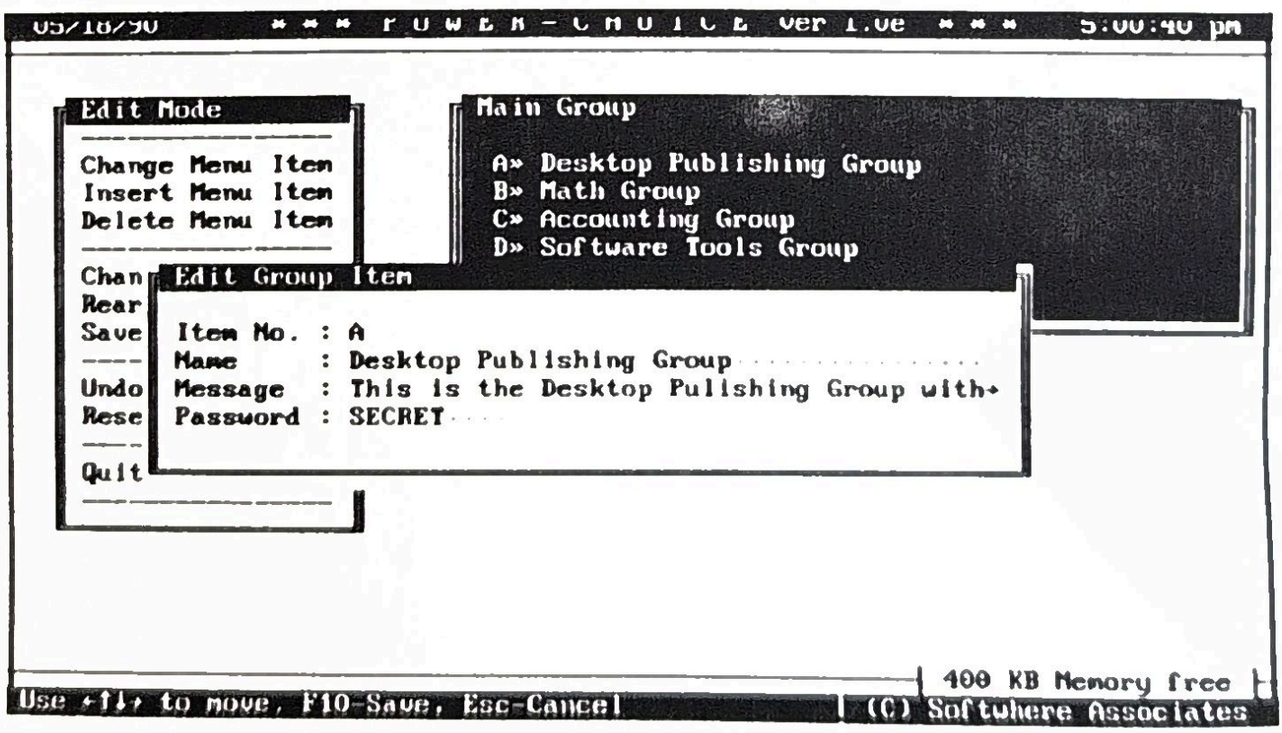
Quit Edit Mode - Returns you to the menu... (Esc does the same thing !)

The Item Entry Screen

This screen will appear when you change or insert an item. If the item is a command item, it will look like this:



For group items, the window will look like this:



Use the cursor keys to move around within the screens. Put the name of the item as you want it to appear later in the "Name" category.

The "Message" category is used to define a message (up to 80 characters long) that will appear at the bottom of the screen when the item is highlighted.

You may also enter an optional password that will be asked for before any operation with the item is done (This includes Change, Delete and Execute it). So don't forget the password !

If you are editing a command item you also have to enter the path in which the program resides, as well as the DOS commands necessary to run it. For example:

To run the program "TEST" on drive C: , you used to type "CD \TESTDIR\DEMO" and "TEST". Now you put "C:\TESTDIR\DEMO" into the "Path" category and "TEST" in the "Command" category.

If a program requires several commands to run, you have to separate the commands with the ASCII sign 179 (Hold the Alt-key down and enter 1 7 9 on the keypad)

If your program (TEST, for example) runs in text mode most the time (i.e. uses no graphics), you might want to have a clock in the upper right corner of the screen at all time. To do this, just put a "Y" behind the "Clock ?" statement.

Some programs leave important messages on the screen when they terminate. To give you time to read this, you

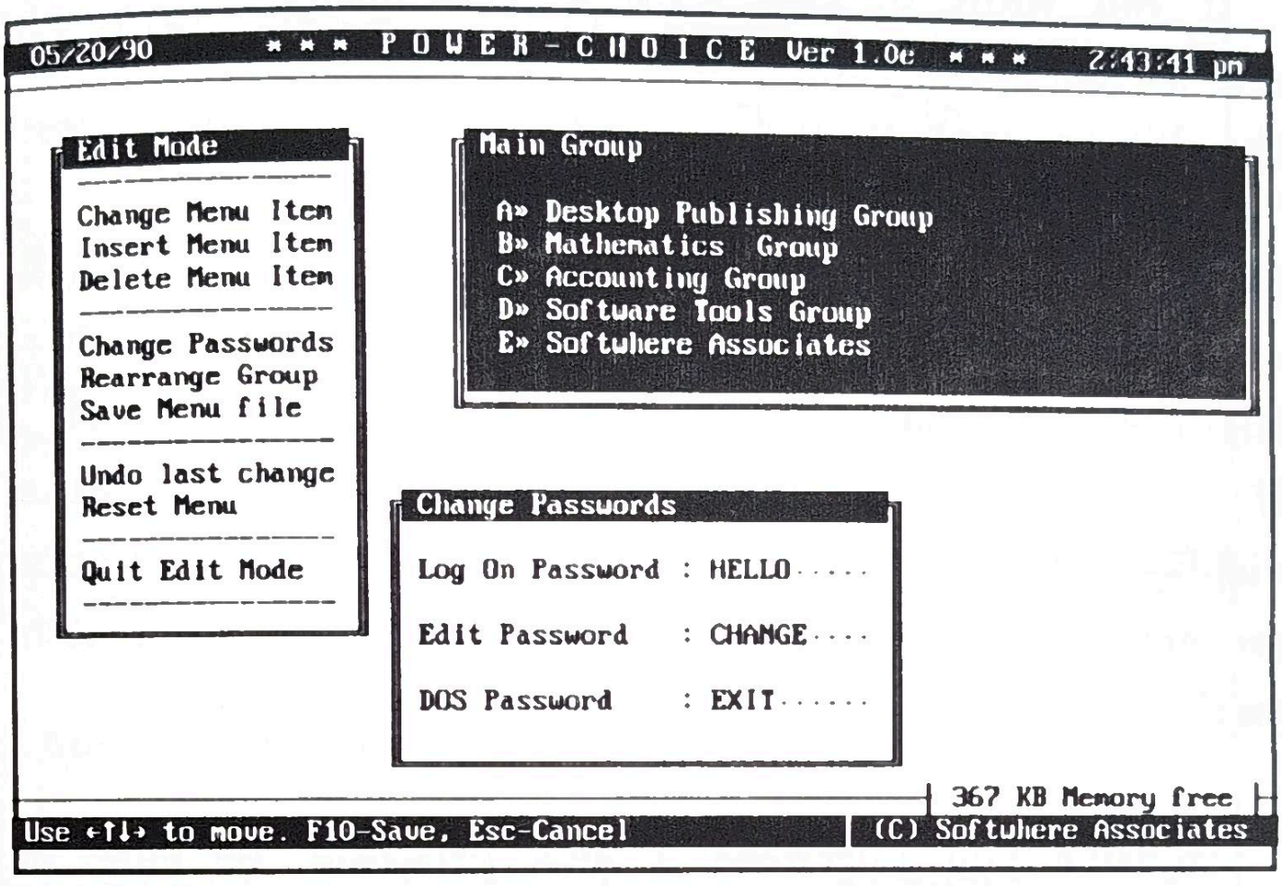
can force **Power-Choice** to wait before returning to the menu screen. Just put a "Y" behind the "Wait ?" statement!

When you are finished editing the entry screen, press F10 to save your changes or Esc to discard them. Several messages may appear when you press F10 to save:
"Specified path not found" indicates that the path you specified in the entry screen does not exist.
"No commands to execute are specified" indicates that you left the command line blank. In both cases it is recommendable to use "Change Item" to correct the mistake.

NOTE: If any problems occur while saving, try to correct the cause immediately or, if not possible, later. But then don't forget to use the "Save Menu" function or all your changes will be lost !

Important!
If the program has to be started with a batch file (extension .BAT), it is necessary to type CALL NAME.BAT where NAME stands for the filename. Otherwise the menu will not return when you exit the program.

The Password Entry Screen



This screen only appears when you select "Change Passwords". Again, use the cursor keys to move and press F10 to save or Esc to discard when you're finished !

Section V - How to use Power-Choice

Once you've installed all of your favorite programs in the menu structure, you can leave the Edit Mode and enjoy the convenience of **Power-Choice**.

To choose from your menu, simply highlight the desired item or press the associated key. (A, B, C, ...) Use the Tab key to return to the parent group.

If you want to exit **Power-Choice** to enter DOS commands, press Esc. **Power-Choice** will then return to the DOS prompt, with a clock in the upper right corner. To reenter **Power-Choice**, type PCH at any time.
NOTE: Whenever the clock is displayed (during DOS shell or any other program) you can press Left-Ctrl + Left-Alt + Right-Shift to disable it. To enable, press the same keys!
If you have installed the screen saver, it will switch off the display every 3 minutes if there was no keypress, mouse movement or any other serial communication. To switch on the display again, simply press any key!

Anytime you purchase a new program, be sure to include it into your **Power-Choice** menu. And remember: **Power-Choice** is flexible ! If you don't like the way you set up your structure, change it. It's that simple !!

Section VI - Trouble-Shooting

This is a short list of problems that might occur. Please read this section if you have any problems before consulting Softwhere Associates for help.

The first part of the table explains general problems that might occur when using **Power-Choice,** the second part describes **Power-Choice's** error messages.

Problem	What you can do
Little dots in the upper right corner of the screen	Try running the program with the clock set to "off"
The screen display flickers and is illegible	Reinstall Power-Choice without the screen saver.
The Power-Choice menu does not return when you quit your program	The file you put in the "command" category is a batch file and requires a "CALL" in front of it.
Message	**What you can do**
Menu file not found or destroyed	Power-Choice could not read the menu file PCHOICE.MNU. You have to rebuild your menu from scratch.
Menu file could not be written to disk	I/O-Error caused trouble. Try to fix the disk and use Save Menu to save.
Disk full! Menu file was not written to disk	Exit Power-Choice and make room on your harddisk !
Backup file for UNDO could not be saved	I/O-Error caused trouble. Try to fix the disk. You won't be able to use UNDO!
UNDO unsuccessful ! Backup file not found	No backup file exists, nothing you can do !
Batch file could not be modified	I/O-Error caused trouble, nothing you can do.
No commands to execute are specified	You edited a command item and did not specify any commands.

Specified path does not exist	You edited a command item and the specified path cannot be accessed.
Item refers to a group that is NOT empty	You cannot delete the item because the group it refers to is not empty.
Group contains only one item	You tried to rearrange a group with only one item.